

Doug Dacy's Dedication to Scott Freeman at the Texas Monetary Conference, 1+2 April 2005

I would like to thank all of the mainstays, organizers and participants in the Texas Monetary Conferences since its inception. In particular I cite Ivan Koenig of the Federal Reserve Bank of Dallas, John Bryant of Rice University, David Papell of the University of Houston, Pepe Auernheimer of Texas A+M University and Nathan Balke of Southern Methodist University. Then, of course, there was our own Scott Freeman, and I am thankful for this opportunity to say a few words about him.

We come not to praise Scott or to add an additional memorial in his name. I am told that he would not approve of yet another memorial. However, I am certain that he would cherish being remembered by his friends gathered here today. We come to acknowledge his contribution to our conference and to recall a few aspects of the life of this truly humane and civil person. Yes, he was a superb monetary economist, but his publications are on record and each of us appreciates his achievements in an area of work he truly loved. But, he had love affairs with other activities and those are the ones that I, his oldest living student, want to touch.

Scott was a fun-loving colleague. He loved parties, good food, beer, and Scotch whiskey. He was a good cook and it has been reported that he even taught his mother a few tricks. He loved reading in different areas of humanities and sciences and speculated that had he not become an economist he would have become an astronomer. He loved the outdoors and the indoors, too, if he could watch a good movie. He loved sporting events, especially those that involved his beloved Green Bay Packers. And as a true cheesehead, he would have been disappointed that his Badgers did not upset the favored Illini in the NCAA basketball semi finals. His love of sports did not spring from his own athleticism. In fact, he could hardly dribble a basketball. His idea of a workout was a long walk in a park or five days of sightseeing in Paris. Perhaps, his favorite pastime was playing a strategy game called Civilization, a game that combined his love of history and strategy. He would go whole nights without sleep pondering his next move.

He loved his niece and nephew and treated them as his own children. He was determined to devote what wealth he might accumulate to their education. And, of course, he loved everyone in this room.

Scott was a study in contradiction. He spoke formally but lived informally. He was an economic conservative and a social liberal. He loved travel but hated flying to get where he wanted to go. He loved all aspects of nature—birds, trees and flowers—but couldn't keep his own plants alive. In his monetary theorizing, money didn't matter, but when it came to the education of his niece and nephew it mattered a lot. And, on neither of these issues would he budge. Given the chance, he might have been the perfect advisor to President Bush on the true meaning of "compassionate conservatism."

In the waning days of his life he had the great fortune of sharing his experiences with a wonderful person, Kristi Shuey. I think that he loved her more than anything else and they were inseparable in his last years. What surely would have been a dreadful ending for a person with terminal illness without her, turned out to be some of the happiest moments of his life. We all remember Lou Gehrig standing there at Yankee Stadium on July 4, 1939 before 61,000 appreciative fans declaring himself to be “the luckiest man on the face of the earth.” Without much exaggeration, I think that Scott felt somewhat the same way and so, if one can die happily, I think that Scott did.

What would Scott say to us today? Have an enjoyable and useful conference, argue with each other about matters of substance and, if you like, raise a toast to me tonight but don't forget to use my superb textbook on monetary economics when appropriate in your classes.